a global AI safety institution. A frontier model released in California or Shenzhen can attack Indian networks or design a pathogen from a laptop in Milan. Safety, therefore, cannot be a standard written only in Washington, Beijing or Brussels. India's own governance framework already says the India AI Safety Institute should anchor our participation in the International Network for Advanced AI Measurement, Evaluation and Science. We should go further and propose the aviation safety architecture for AI: common testing protocols, shared incident reporting, joint red-teaming, cyber and biological evaluations and agreed thresholds for dangerous capabilities. This would be an ICAO (International Civil Aviation Organization)-style architecture, with national institutes operating under common international standards and coordinated through a permanent secretariat.

Second, India should back safe, regulated open-weight AI. Closed frontier models create dependency. Fully unrestricted frontier weights create catastrophic risk. Open weights give India what a foreign API (application programming interface) never can, which is the ability to inspect, modify, fine-tune, secure, air-gap, and independently run a model inside our own jurisdiction. For models above defined capability thresholds, release should require rigorous evaluation and graduated access. Open-weight AI can prevent a future where intelligence is controlled only by the US or China. India should therefore fund and help establish a globally governed open-weight company, safety-certified by the international institute, that does for AI what Red Hat did for enterprise Linux.

Third, and most urgently, India must build gigawatt-scale AI compute to which Indian institutions have guaranteed access. There is no sovereign AI without sovereign compute. India today has about 1.6 GW of operational data centre capacity, and the IndiaAI shared compute pool has crossed 45,000 GPUs (graphics processing units). These figures sound large until placed beside what the frontier requires. Microsoft alone is reportedly planning roughly 38 GW of owned and leased global data centre capacity by 2032.

Announced projects such as AirTrunk's 5 GW plan are welcome, but physical location in India is not the same as sovereign control. A facility whose capacity is contracted to global hyperscalers may serve Indian customers on commercial terms, yet it gives Indian researchers and public institutions no guaranteed access. The policy, therefore, cannot just be "build data centres". It must be Indian-owned GPUs, electricity, cooling, fibre, cloud orchestration and secure training facilities, with a share reserved for Indian universities, startups and public agencies.

The sums are large. AirTrunk's $30 billion covers the buildings and power, and Anthropic's recent Broadcom arrangement priced a single gigawatt of fully equipped AI compute at about $35 billion. A 5 GW sovereign compute program over five years would therefore require well over $100 billion, or upward of Rs 9.5 lakh crore, once accelerators and supporting infrastructure are included. Capital can be raised through a National AI Infrastructure Fund modelled on the NIIF (National Investment and Infrastructure Fund). This is also energy policy. Five gigawatts of compute needs more than 5 GW of continuous electrical supply once cooling and other facility loads are counted.

AI safety must be globally regulated. Weights must stay open because otherwise intelligence will get monopolised by a few foreign firms. Compute must be Indian so that our models can run on our data centres. We built sovereign digital infrastructure for the internet age. We must now build sovereign intelligence infrastructure for the AI age. ■

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TAKEAWAYS

- India cannot afford to run essential systems on foreign-controlled AI that could be restricted by another government
- India should push for an international AI safety regime with common testing, incident reporting, red-teaming and risk thresholds
- Regulated open-weight models would let India inspect, adapt, secure and run AI systems within its own jurisdiction
- India needs massive Indian-owned AI compute capacity, backed by power, infrastructure and reserved access for Indian institutions